

SECTION 6

Managing Your Well-Being and Growth

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How Leaders Can Get the Feedback They Need to Grow

by Kim Scott, Liz Fosslien, and Mollie West Duffy

When uncertainty is high, knowing where you stand—and learning about your mistakes while there's still time to fix them—is more important than ever. To be able to adapt to changing conditions and ensure that your team continues to feel supported and motivated, you need to understand what you're doing well—and where you're falling short. Soliciting clear, actionable feedback allows you to make better, more informed decisions and pivot when necessary.

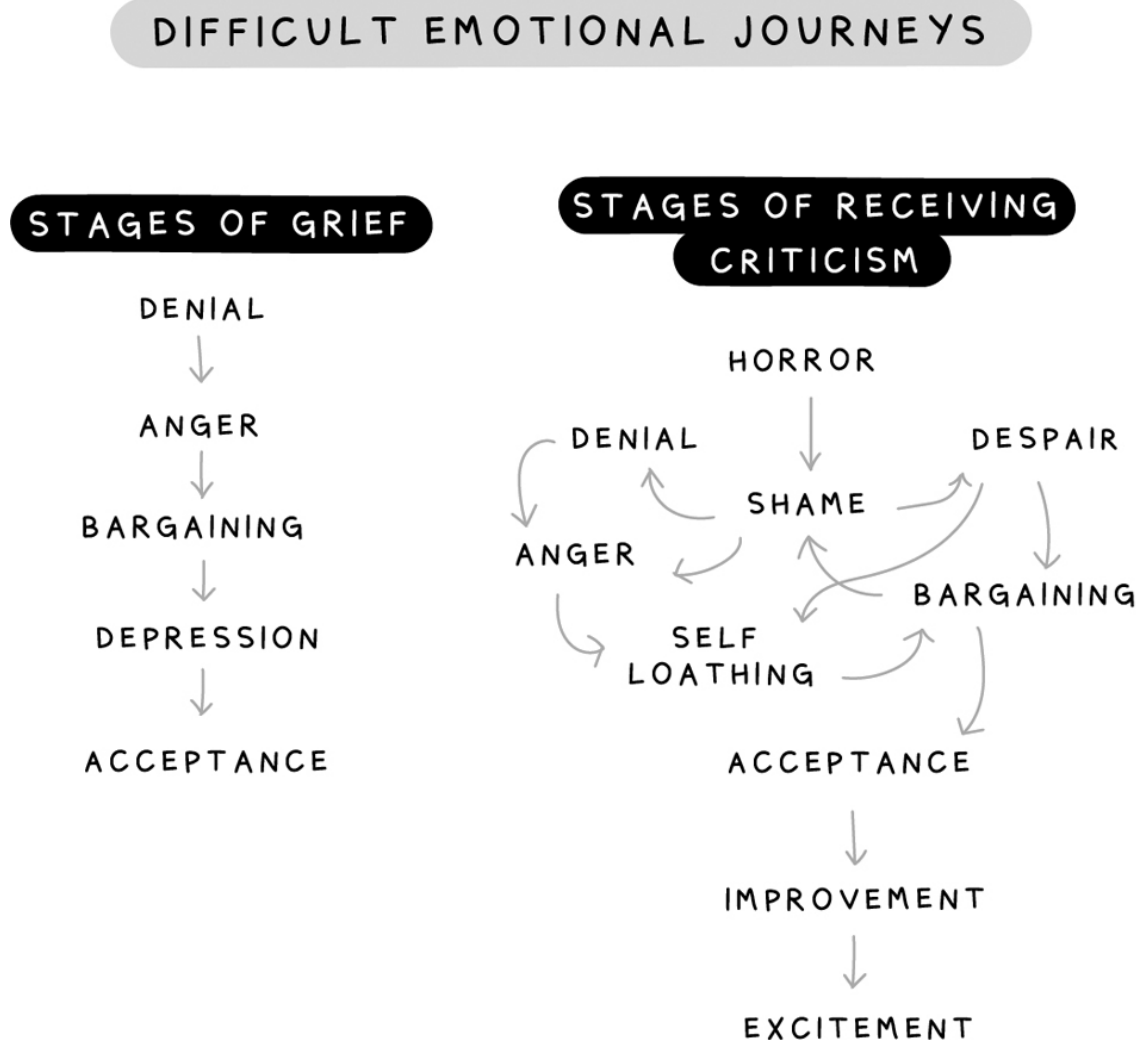
Asking for feedback also creates a culture of trust and transparency. When employees feel like their input matters, they're more likely to remain loyal, engaged, and productive. They're also much more willing to surface valuable concerns and suggestions.

But uncertainty also makes it much, much harder to get honest feedback. When people feel anxious or like their jobs might be in jeopardy, they're more reticent to speak up, especially to management. Add to that the fact that when people move up the ranks in an organization, they tend to get less corrective feedback, even though a 2014 study by Jack Zenger and Joseph Folkman showed that by a three-to-one margin, people believe corrective feedback does more to improve their performance than positive feedback.¹

In other words, right when you need it most, getting an accurate pulse on your performance as a leader becomes really, really hard. So how do you get feedback when people are least likely to offer it? How can you solicit actionable, useful advice from your reports? Neither one of you wants to have a hard conversation, but when you're the leader, it's your job to overcome that reluctance for yourself and help the other person overcome it, too.

Knowing how and when to ask for feedback is a learned skill—as is checking your (normal) defensive reaction in the face of helpful criticism (see [figure 17-1](#)). Based on our books and research, we put our heads together to outline the specific steps leaders should take to ask for feedback. The first thing to do is to ask for criticism. This is awkward at best and can be a difficult emotional journey, so here are six tips for how to successfully solicit Radical Candor from your employees.

FIGURE 17-1



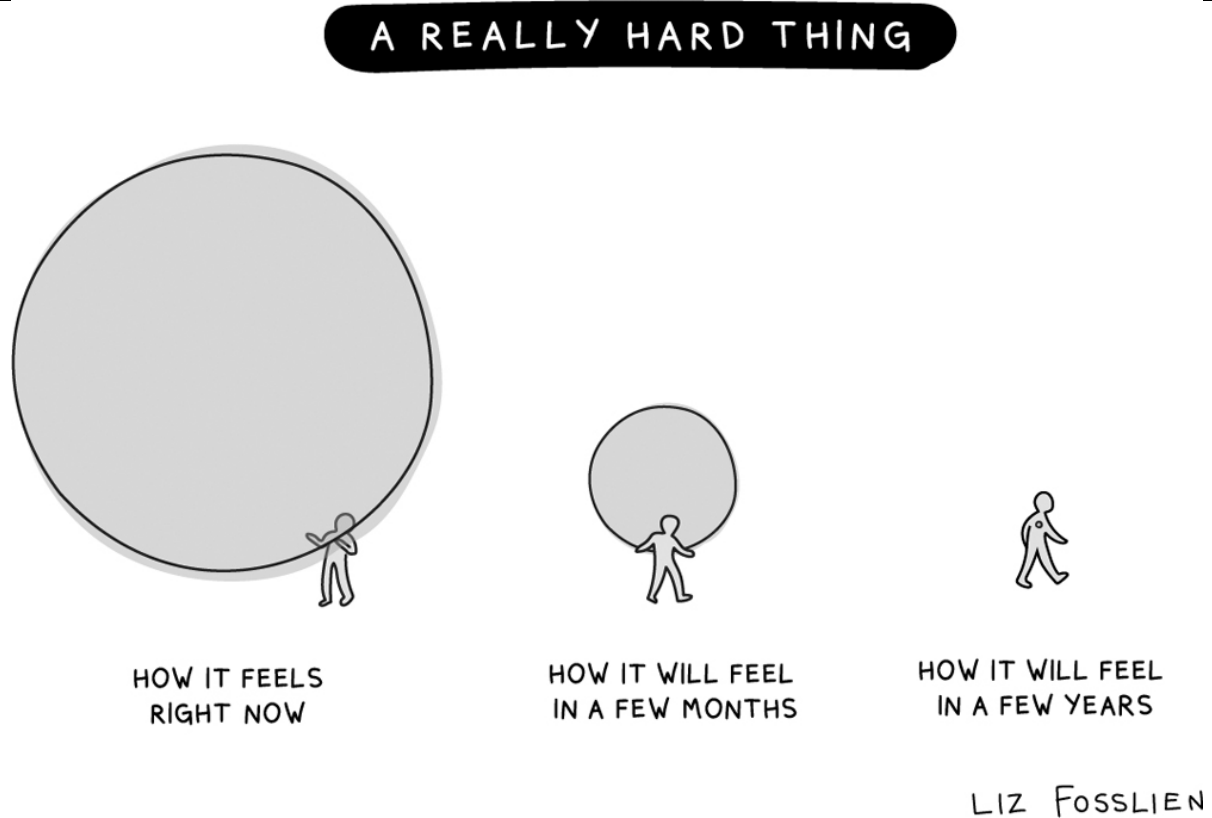
LIZ FOSSLIE

Embrace Feeling Negative Emotions—Often

Hearing what you need to improve rarely feels good. Ask yourself: How many times each week do the people you work with tell you things that make you anxious, upset, or even defensive? How often do they tell you things that make you feel wonderful? If it's all feel-good praise and no hard-to-hear criticism, beware! You're not getting the real story. You need to work harder to get them to criticize you.

Remember, when it comes to soliciting Radical Candor, good news is no news, no news is bad news, and bad news is good news. As one of Liz's former managers told her, "Someone who cares about you tells you that you have food on your face. Everyone else will stay mum because they don't want to feel uncomfortable." Even though criticism is hard to hear in the moment, you need it to get better over time—and in time, it will sting less, too. (See [figure 17-2](#).)

FIGURE 17-2



Have a Go-To Question

It can be awkward to ask people point-blank about what's going on. And when things are uncertain, it can feel risky to them to say what they actually think. We recommend that you come up with a go-to question that establishes psychological safety. There are three elements to a good go-to question:

- The question cannot be answered with a yes or a no, or an “Oh, no, everything is fine”—which is exactly the answer you'll get most of the time if you ask, “Do you have any feedback for me?” Liz and Mollie love the question “What's one thing can I do to support you?” By asking for “one thing,” you make it much more likely that you'll get a specific, actionable response.
- Your question must sound like you—something you would naturally say. The question Kim likes to use is, “What could I do or stop doing that would make it easier to work with me?” However, if those words don't fall easily off your tongue, find ones that do.
- Your question must be adapted for the person you're talking to. Jason Rosoff, who cofounded Radical Candor with Kim, told her he hates her go-to question, so she needs to ask him a more specific one.

Consider making your go-to question a recurring part of your one-on-one agendas. If your team knows what you'll be asking ahead of time, they'll have more time to prepare a useful answer.

Embrace the Other Person's Discomfort

No matter how good your go-to question is, the other person is likely to feel uncomfortable. And you're likely to feel uncomfortable because they're uncomfortable. It can be tempting to let the person off the hook at this point. But if you do that, you'll never get the feedback you need to succeed.

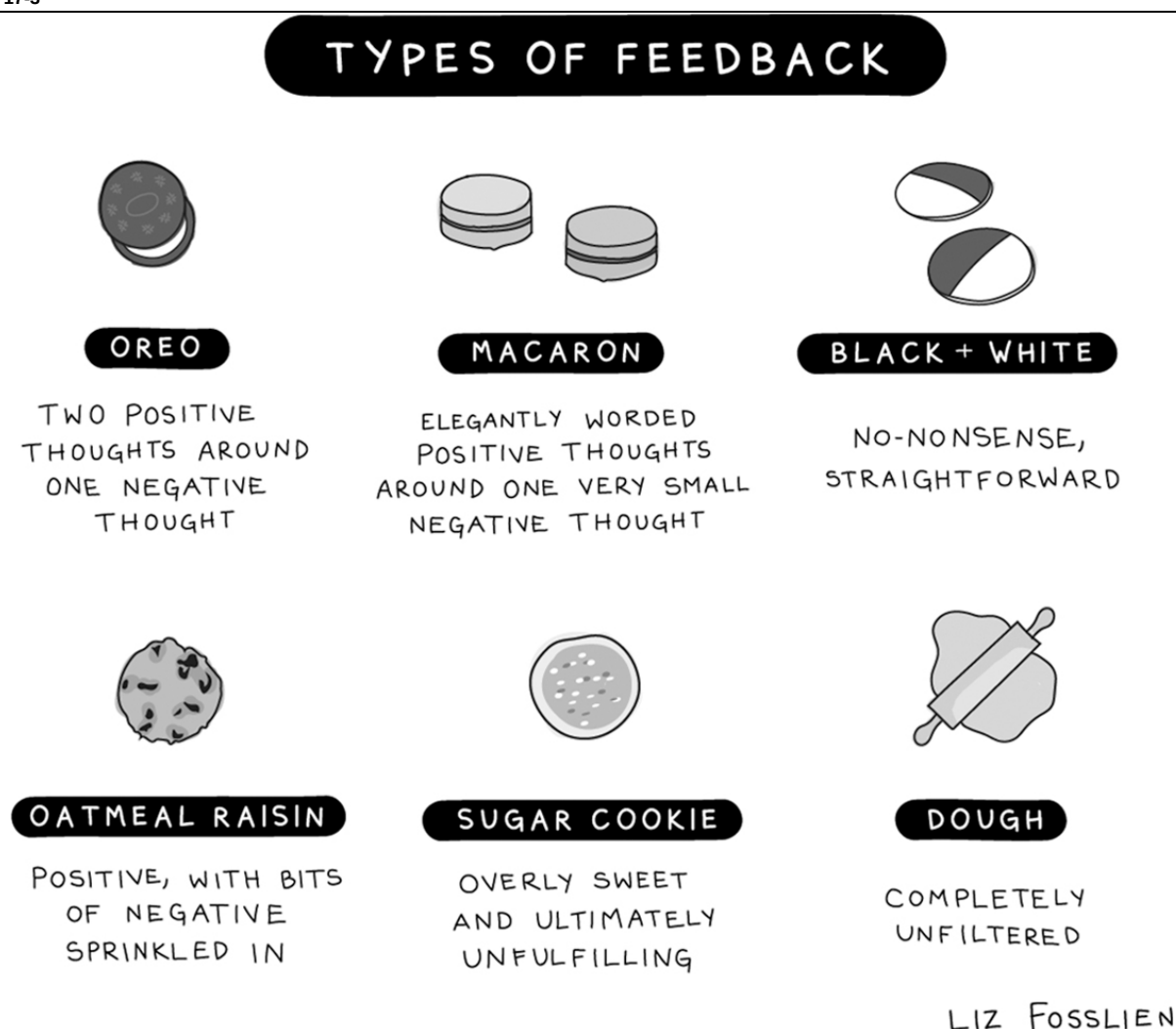
The only way out of this discomfort is through it. Try asking your question and then remaining silent. Count to six, slowly, in your head. Very few people can endure six full seconds of silence. They'll tell you something.

Listen to Understand, Not to Respond

When listening to feedback, your motivation matters. You should want to understand what the other person is telling you, rather than listening so that you can deliver a response. It's the difference between, "I hear what you are saying, thank you" (great) and "I hear what you are saying, but ..." (not so great).

Feedback opens us up to seeing our behaviors from different points of view. If we're focused on defending ourselves, we lose out on the opportunity to learn and improve. A helpful hint about listening to understand: *Look* for the criticism. Often people will hide it. Sometimes you'll get Oreo feedback: two positive thoughts around a negative one. Make sure you don't miss the criticism. Other times the feedback will be more like an oatmeal raisin cookie. Don't miss the raisins! (For an illustration of types of feedback, see [figure 17-3](#).)

FIGURE 17-3



Close the Loop: Make Your Listening Tangible

The best way to ensure you'll continue receiving feedback is to follow up and share the actions you've taken based on what you heard.

When you receive critical comments, it's useful to immediately outline what you'll do with the suggestions or concerns that were flagged. Try, "Here's what I'll do moving forward." And remember: You don't need to promise to make massive changes (you might not be able to deliver on those promises). You can say something like, "My next step will be to talk to other leaders to see what's possible."

Take former Netflix CEO and now executive chairman Reed Hastings, who receives an annual 360-degree written assessment that any employee could contribute to. Hastings closed the loop on his 2019 360 by writing a memo to all Netflix employees. Here's an excerpt from his book *No Rules Rules*:

I find the best comments for my growth are unfortunately the most painful. So, in the spirit of 360, thank you for bravely and honestly pointing out to me: "In meetings you can skip over topics or rush through them when you feel impatient or determine a particular topic on the agenda is no longer worth the time.... On a similar note, watch out for letting your point-of-view overwhelm. You can short-change the debate by signaling alignment when it doesn't exist." So true, so sad, and so frustrating that I still do this. I will keep working on it.

Once you've taken action, make sure you share the changes you've made. Ask if you under- or overcorrected. Helpful hint: If the problem is something you've struggled with for some time, it's usually a good idea to try to overcorrect. If you get feedback that you move too fast, work on slowing down until someone tells you you're moving too slowly.

And if you weren't able to do anything differently, communicate why. When an employee told Kim she interrupted him and other employees in meetings, she wore a rubber band to her next staff meeting, told everyone about the feedback, and asked for help in changing this deeply ingrained bad habit that she couldn't realistically change overnight. She asked people to snap the rubber band on her wrist when they noticed her interrupting. (She knew that the people on her team would actually do that, and with a laugh—you might decide to take a different approach.) The rubber band helped her interrupt less. But more importantly, it made her listening tangible—and explained that although she couldn't change things overnight, she was working on it.

One of the biggest missteps we see leaders take is staying silent when, after careful consideration, they realize they're unable to act on feedback. When employees never hear back after giving feedback, they'll assume that their suggestions were ignored. It's much, much better to come back to your team and say something like, "Unfortunately, due to the executive team's priorities for the quarter, we won't be able to do ———, but I'm going to keep it in mind," than to say nothing at all.

Make Giving Feedback—Not Venting— a Team Habit

Consistent venting, when you rehash the same problems without trying to understand or solve them, can make you and your team feel worse. This is because you're ingraining the frustration in your brain by talking about it over and over, without actually focusing on what can be learned or changed.

Even worse is when a person doesn't feel safe giving feedback to another person and instead vents their frustrations to a neutral third party. This may make the frustrated person feel better in the moment, but it doesn't solve anything long term, since the other person is oblivious to their frustrating behaviors. When someone comes and talks to you about someone else who is not in the room, it may feel like you're being an empathetic listener. But really all you're doing is stirring the political pot. Instead, encourage them to go talk directly with the other person. Offer your services as a mediator but remind them that it still requires both of them to talk to you at the same time. There are obvious exceptions—if a person is being bullied or harassed, don't tell them to go work it out directly.

Make feedback a team habit so that people feel safe giving it directly instead of venting to someone else. The place to start is soliciting feedback. If everyone is soliciting feedback, it's more likely to be met with open ears.

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When things are up in the air, it can feel comforting to avoid difficult feedback. But creating stability for your team—and success for your organization—depends on your ability to learn what needs to change. Burying your head in the sand is never the safe thing to do. A culture of ruinous empathy or false harmony is not the path to success. Instead, invite criticism.

QUICK RECAP

Creating stability for your team depends on your ability to solicit feedback on what needs change.

- Embrace feeling negative emotions. Criticism may be hard to hear, but you need it to improve.
 - Have a go-to question, such as, “What could I do or stop doing that would make it easier to work with me?”
 - Embrace the other person’s discomfort. After asking your question, remain silent.
 - Listen to fully understand what the other person is telling you, rather than planning your response.
 - Follow up on the feedback you’ve received and share the actions you’ve taken.
 - Make giving feedback a team habit by encouraging individuals to speak directly to each other.
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Adapted from content posted on hbr.org, March 10, 2023 (product #H07IRN).

How can you ask for and get quality feedback, react to it (good or bad), and grow from it? Watch this video:



18

How Managers Can Make Time for Their Own Development

by Helen Tupper and Sarah Ellis

Being a successful manager today is a tough task that requires grappling with multiple “ands”: supporting team members *and* influencing senior stakeholders; making progress on the day job *and* troubleshooting unexpected problems; delivering on quarterly objectives *and* thinking strategically. In the midst of the “and” overload, it’s not surprising that managers tend to be the least likely people in an organization to prioritize their own career development.

We support thousands of managers every year who share a sense of frustration that their career development is stalling but struggle to find the time to invest in their own learning. We’ve observed three common career development mistakes managers make and uncovered a few tried-and-tested solutions to help them balance the demands of the day-to-day with investing in their own growth.

The Say-Do Development Gap

Our clients often tell us that they find coaching and supporting their team members’ career development to be a motivating and enjoyable part of their managerial role—and yet they undervalue the importance of modeling this behavior themselves.

When teams don’t see their manager investing in their own growth, it creates a say-do development gap, which has a negative ripple effect for both managers and their teams: Team members lose confidence that committing time to their professional development is the right thing to do and may even question whether their manager really values continual learning. At the same time, managers miss out on important moments to develop skills and capabilities to improve their performance and support their ambitions for the future.

What to do differently: Share learning goals

One simple and effective way for managers to avoid the say-do development gap is to share their learning goals openly with their teams. Sharing development priorities has multiple benefits. First, it prompts managers to identify what they want to focus on, and sharing their goals increases accountability. Second, involving team members means that managers are surrounding themselves with more people to support their growth and removes the idea that learning from others is linked to levels and hierarchy. Finally, when team members see their managers setting and sticking to development goals, it prompts them to do the same.

For example, a manager who shares a learning goal to increase their internal profile might benefit from a team member spotting an opportunity for them to speak at an event. A manager looking to develop their ability to use data to drive decisions could be supported with feedback from their team members on what they currently do well and what could be better.

When approached in this way, development doesn't need to be another thing that gets added to a manager's to-do list; it becomes part of their daily work and is accelerated by the people who work for them.

The Bubble Barrier

With so many demands on their workdays, it's understandable that managers rarely spend time on development outside of their organization. The challenge of finding the time and opportunity to learn in different places and with new people often feels insurmountable and falls into the category of "should do" rather than "will do."

Relying on internal-only opportunities results in managers developing a narrow view of the world and limits their learning. And operating in the bubble of internal knowledge and networks means that managers are reinforcing who and what they already know rather than cultivating their curiosity. Managers need to learn beyond the internal bubble so that it doesn't become a barrier to their growth.

What to do differently: Knowledge-swap sessions

An efficient way to bring the outside in is to approach peers in a noncompeting organization to cohost a team development session, where both teams share their expertise with each other. For example, a team with agile expertise could knowledge swap with a team that has strong communication capabilities. Or an established team in a large organization might spend time with a team from a smaller startup, exchanging insights on innovation in different operating contexts.

These knowledge-swap sessions allow everyone to spend time in a different working world, create new connections, and learn together (which also supports overcoming the say-do gap). The format of a swap session can range from a virtual hour over lunch to a full day in a meeting room. Holding knowledge swaps gives managers—and their teams—regular opportunities to learn from people outside the organization in a way that's part of their existing rhythm of work, rather than something extra to squeeze in.

The Time Trap

We often hear managers say, "I don't have time to invest in my development. I'll get around to it when everything calms down, or when this project has finished, or when I've recruited this person," and so on. This way of thinking keeps many managers stuck in a time trap, which will hold their career back over the long term.

These time traps aren't a result of managers making excuses—they reflect the reality of the challenges they're dealing with. The mistake is the hope that one day we'll magically have more time and fewer things to do. If managers look for the perfect moment to focus on their development, they're likely to be left waiting and stagnating in their career.

What to do differently: Manager micro-learning moments

Many people still associate development with formal learning methods like taking a course. But what managers need are small, easy ways to make development part of their day-to-day. Practicing micro-learning moments is a memorable and simple way for managers to kick-start the habit of continual improvement. Effective micro-learning moments usually take less than 10 minutes, and they're small but significant in their impact, as managers benefit from a compound effect of continual learning over time. Here are a few examples:

Fast feedback: Ask your team members to answer the same fast feedback question: "What three words would you use to describe me at my best?" This simple question gives managers instant insight into whether their intent is matching their impact.

One-minute weekly review: End your week by spending one minute jotting down the answers to these two self-awareness questions: What has given me the most energy this week? What could have been better this week?

Strength accelerator: Pick one skill you want to strengthen and identify an action related to regularity (how could you use that strength more?), range (where else could you use that strength that you don't today?), or reach (who could you share that strength with?).

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The more managers take control of their development, the better able they'll be to avoid the career mistakes that will get in the way of their growth. And the more their team members see the positive impact of investing in career development, the more likely they are to do the same.

QUICK RECAP

Managers tend to be the least likely people in an organization to prioritize their own professional development. How can you make time to learn and grow in your role?

- **Share your learning goals openly with your team.** This will help you stay accountable and garner support for your team members.
 - **Set up knowledge-sharing sessions.** Host knowledge swaps where external groups share their expertise with your team, and vice versa.
 - **Find moments for micro-learning.** Find regular time—10 minutes or less—to devote to your development, including soliciting feedback, a weekly review, or a strength accelerator exercise.
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Adapted from content posted on hbr.org, June 29, 2023 (product #H07PI4).

19

You Don't Have to Put Yourself Last

by Nataly Kogan

Do you want to be a great leader? There is one skill you need to master that doesn't get nearly enough attention: emotional fitness.

If this is not what you expected, I'm not surprised. Every day, dozens of articles discuss how leaders must focus on improving the well-being of their teams. The popular adage of "leaders eat last" has become the standard, suggesting to many new managers that, as leaders, they need to sacrifice their well-being for that of the people they lead.

To be transparent, I bought into this advice when I was starting out in my career. For the next 15 years as a leader in technology and finance, I cared deeply about the people on my teams and prioritized their health and success over mine. I was exhausted and overwhelmed and took that as a sign that I was doing things right. I adopted the mentality that being a great leader meant being a martyr, never pausing to process my anxiety or self-doubt. All the while, I did my best to put on a confident and positive act before my team.

But my pretending didn't work forever, and eventually, I completely burned out. I almost lost everything, including the company I had founded, my family, and my health. This was the darkest, most difficult time in my life, but it taught me a powerful leadership lesson: To be a truly impactful and caring leader, I had to put myself and my emotional fitness at the top of my priority list.

What Is Emotional Fitness?

I define emotional fitness as the skill of creating a more supportive relationship with yourself, your thoughts and feelings, and other people. The way we treat others is rooted in how we treat ourselves. That means it doesn't matter how much you care about the people you lead if you don't lead *yourself* with awareness, compassion, and a consistent investment in fueling your emotional, mental, and physical energy.

The painful reality I discovered after burning out is that I wasn't fooling my team by pretending that I was doing fine when I wasn't. Instead, I was causing them unnecessary stress and creating a culture that lacked psychological trust, which research has shown to be one of the top requirements for successful teams.

As human beings, we're great at communicating our emotions using facial expressions and body language. It's like we're all wearing an emotional whiteboard on which our feelings are displayed. Other people can see them through slightly foggy glasses: They sense how we feel but don't know exactly, and when you are in a position of power and influence, you can bet that your team is watching. If they sense that you are secretly struggling, they are going to waste time and energy trying to guess why. In my case, this led to a spiral of mistrust.

What's more, human emotions are contagious. This is particularly true within teams and between bosses and the people who report to them. Your team members can literally catch your emotions.

What Can Emotional Fitness Do for You?

If you're not already convinced that emotional fitness needs to be your number one priority, consider that it will allow you—and your team—to perform at your best. Greater well-being and happiness dramatically improve our productivity, creativity, and ability to make decisions and help others. Your well-being and emotional fitness are direct investments in you and your success.

Further, you can't teach what you don't do. You can tell the people you manage to take breaks or practice self-care, but if you don't do it yourself, they will not take your efforts seriously. When leaders carry out sustainable work practices, their team members are more engaged, have greater well-being, are more likely to stay at the organization, and have more trust. Your team will do what you do, not what you say.

How Do You Strengthen Your Emotional Fitness?

Here are three science-backed practices to begin or add to what you're already doing.

Practice emotional awareness by checking in with yourself

Get into the habit of asking yourself: “How am I feeling right now?” Do this each morning, and it will eventually become more natural to do it throughout the day.

Don't judge your answers; the purpose of this practice is simply to become aware of how you're feeling in the moment. Research shows that people who practice emotional awareness have greater well-being, because awareness gives you choices.¹ Based on how you feel, you can decide to do something to support yourself or to share a bit about your emotional whiteboard with your team, loved ones, or support system. In fact, I recommend you do so if you know you're feeling off or your energy is different from normal.

This is also a great practice to do with your team: take a few minutes during a meeting to go around and check in, asking everyone to share a few words about what's on their emotional whiteboard. This requires vulnerability and can be challenging, but by going first you give permission to everyone else to do it, too. I've witnessed teams build a greater sense of openness and connection through this exercise, which fuels everyone, including you as a leader.

Schedule mini fuel-ups throughout the day

Begin by scheduling one 15- to 20-minute break, with the goal of having at least two. Put it on your calendar and when the time comes, ask yourself: “What can I do right now to refuel and reset?” Then do it! Even a short, 10-minute walk can boost your mood, improve focus and motivation, and reduce stress.

If you only have five minutes to spare, make the best use of that time. Quality matters more than quantity, as long as what you do helps you to disconnect from your work and fuels your mental, emotional, or physical energy.

Here's a bonus idea: End your next team meeting 15 minutes early and tell everyone to spend the time doing something that fuels their energy. Ask them to report back and tell you what they did (this increases accountability), and make sure you participate.

Cultivate a daily gratitude habit

Our brains have what's called a negativity bias, which means that we are more focused on noticing what's wrong than what's good or positive. The negativity bias is useful in helping us survive (danger comes with negative stimuli), but not thrive, and constantly focusing on what's wrong and ignoring what's good depletes your energy, increases stress, and makes it difficult to gain clarity when making decisions.

The best way to counter your natural negativity bias is to practice gratitude and make it a daily habit. There is a mountain of studies that show how gratitude improves well-being and resilience.

My favorite practice is called the “morning gratitude lens”: Before you grab your phone, read the news, or check social media or email in the morning, pause and think of three things you're grateful for. Be specific and zoom in on small things: “I am grateful for having a few minutes to drink my coffee this morning” is better than “I

am grateful for my health.” Specificity helps your brain pause and really feel the gratitude. Jot down what you are grateful for in a journal, on a Post-it Note, or in the Notes app on your phone.

I also encourage you to become more intentional about expressing your gratitude to people you manage. Being on the receiving end of gratitude doesn’t just feel good, but also increases motivation and engagement, and can build a stronger sense of connection and trust within a team.

Remember: You can’t give what you don’t have.

This is the advice I would give to my younger self. If you want to be a great leader, which means you want to positively impact other people’s capacity to thrive, you have to begin by positively impacting your own capacity to thrive. Practicing your emotional fitness skills of awareness, energy management, and gratitude is a great way to start.

QUICK RECAP

To be a great leader, you need to master the skill of emotional fitness.

- Get into the habit of asking yourself: “How am I feeling right now?” Based on how you feel, you can decide to do something to support yourself or to share how you’re feeling with your team, loved ones, or support system.
 - Schedule at least one 15- to 20-minute break every day. When the time comes, ask yourself: “What can I do right now to refuel and reset?” Then do it.
 - Cultivate a daily gratitude habit to improve your well-being and resilience. Pause and think of three specific things you’re grateful for.
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Adapted from content posted on hbr.org, January 24, 2022.

For more on self-awareness as a leader, listen to this podcast:

